the people of Bokhara and Khiva from despotic rulers.[80] The removal of khan Abd Allah and emir Alim (and the Bolshevik justification for their actions) was unsurprisingly a concern to the emir of Afghanistan. Amanullah's own position was somewhat unstable and his control within his country 'loose and undefined'.[81] To align himself too firmly with the Soviet government could place the emir in danger of one day being deposed just like his fellow Muslim rulers. Nevertheless, the emir was also aware of the advantages that were to be had 'by raising Bolshevist...bogeys' against Britain.[82] For the Indian government's part, while it could not allow Afghanistan to use Bolshevism as blackmail to force concessions, it was also aware that having its neighbour, at the very least, as a neutral buffer against Soviet Russia was invaluable.

The Indian government's objective during 1920, therefore, was to prevent Afghanistan from moving closer to Soviet Russia, by emphasising the dangerous potential of friendship with the Bolshevik regime as compared to the benefits of good relations with Britain. While this had always been the policy of Chelmsford and his men, with the Bolshevik successes in Asia in 1920 it became even more imperative to keep Afghanistan on side.[83] Hamilton Grant had noted himself, as early as November 1919, the opportunity that existed to drive a wedge between the Bolshevik regime and Afghanistan:

There is every indication that the Amir's ambitions are for the moment turned mainly towards enlarging his borders or influence in Central Asia. We hear that his representatives at Merv and Bokhara are posing as protectors of Mussalmans against the tyranny of Bolshevist [sic] communism; and if this policy is pursued, it seems bound to bring Afghanistan into collision with the Bolshevists [sic] and to throw them definitely into our arms. But the decision hangs in the balance.[84]

The question, as Montagu put it, was whether the Indian government could 'hold out inducements to him [the emir] that will suffice to turn [the] scale